



These hardwoods all come from Côte d'Ivoire.



LUMBER INDUSTRY

Côte d'Ivoire once had vast areas of forest, containing ebony, mahogany, and other hardwood trees. Today hardly any is left. For years the country's economy was heavily dependent on the logging industry. Lumber exports were seen as vital for paying off foreign debts, and large areas of forest were cleared to make way for coffee and cocoa plantations. A program was recently started to help save the forests and plant new ones.



YAMOOUSSOUKRO

The dome of the world's largest church rises up above the rooftops of Yamoussoukro, a small town in the center of the country which became Côte d'Ivoire's capital city in 1983. Personally overseen by former president Boigny, the cathedral was completed in 1989 at huge cost. It seats 7,000 people and has an open-air area for another 350,000 – three times the city's population. There has been much controversy about undertaking such an extravagant project in a country with widespread poverty.



Many of Abidjan's banks and businesses are based in the skyscrapers of the Plateau district.

ABIDJAN

This modern port, with its glittering glass skyscrapers, is the country's largest city. Abidjan is filled with stylish shops and restaurants that show a powerful French influence, reminding visitors of Côte d'Ivoire's historical ties with France. It was also the country's capital until 1983, when Yamoussoukro took over that role.



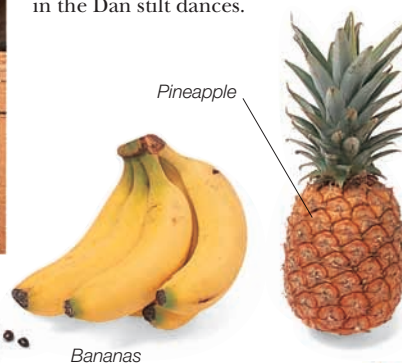
CÔTE D'IVOIRE

Capital city:	Yamoussoukro
Area:	124,502 sq miles (322,460 sq km)
Population:	16,600,000
Official language:	French
Major religions:	Muslim 38%, Christian 31%, traditional beliefs 25%, other 6%
Government:	Multiparty democracy
Currency:	CFA franc
Adult literacy rate:	50%
Life expectancy:	45 years
People per doctor:	10,000
Televisions:	70 per 1,000 people



ETHNIC GROUPS

More than 60 ethnic groups live side-by-side in Côte d'Ivoire, with relatively few clashes. The Dan people, for example, live deep in the heart of the western forests and are famous for their carving skills. They make wooden masks that are worn by the members of special secret societies to keep their identities hidden. Only members of these societies are allowed to take part in the Dan stilt dances.



Coffee beans

Bananas

THE ECONOMY

Compared to much of West Africa, Côte d'Ivoire is a fairly prosperous country. This is partly the result of a policy of growing a variety of crops. Côte d'Ivoire is the world's leading cocoa grower – in some years, it produces about a third of the world's cocoa exports. However, competition from elsewhere may change this. It is also Africa's biggest coffee producer and grows vast numbers of pineapples and bananas.

World's top five cocoa producers

Figures show the share of total world cocoa production.



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